Annexation (“Manifest Destiny”)

John L. O'Sullivan · July 1845

Source: John L. O'Sullivan, “Annexation,” United States Magazine and Democratic Review (1845). Public domain. Principal passages of the essay.

> Defending the annexation of Texas, O'Sullivan coined the era's rallying cry: it was America's “manifest destiny to overspread the continent,” a Providence-given right that justified westward expansion to the Pacific.

COMPLETE TEXT — UNEDITED

It is now time for the opposition to the Annexation of Texas to cease, all further agitation of the waters of bitterness and strife, at least in connection with this question. Texas is now ours. She is no longer to us a mere country on the map. She comes within the dear and sacred designation of Our Country.

Why, were other reasoning wanting, in favor of now elevating this question of the reception of Texas into the Union, out of the lower region of our past party dissensions, up to its proper level of a high and broad nationality, it surely is to be found, found abundantly, in the manner in which other nations have undertaken to intrude themselves into it, between us and the proper parties to the case, in a spirit of hostile interference against us, for the avowed object of thwarting our policy and hampering our power, limiting our greatness and checking the fulfillment of our manifest destiny to overspread the continent allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions.

California will, probably, next fall away from the loose adhesion which, in such a country as Mexico, holds a remote province in a slight equivocal kind of dependence on the metropolis. The Anglo-Saxon foot is already on its borders. Already the advance guard of the irresistible army of Anglo-Saxon emigration has begun to pour down upon it, armed with the plow and the rifle, and marking its trail with schools and colleges, courts and representative halls, mills and meeting-houses. A population will soon be in actual occupation of California, over which it will be idle for Mexico to dream of dominion. They will necessarily become independent.

Their right to independence will be the natural right of self-government belonging to any community strong enough to maintain it — distinct in position, origin, and character, and free from any mutual obligations of membership of a common political body. And by this title, there can be no doubt that the population now fast streaming down upon California will both assert and maintain that independence.

Away, then, with all idle French talk of balances of power on the American continent. And whosoever may hold the balance, though they should cast into the opposite scale all the bayonets and cannon, not only of France and England, but of Europe entire, how would it kick the beam against the simple, solid weight of the two hundred and fifty, or three hundred millions — and American millions — destined to gather beneath the flutter of the stripes and stars, in the fast hastening year of the Lord 1945!